THE 5 SKILLS, WITH A TEST AND A PROMPT FOR EACH

5 AI Skills Your Manager Notices

Dennis · Sr PM at Microsoft · @dennisthinks_

Five skills, one test and one prompt for each. Every move runs on work already on your plate this week.

1 AI Systems Evaluation

Take one AI draft you plan to send this week. Before it goes out, run 5 hard cases against it: a wrong name, a moved date, a changed number, a missing owner, a claim with no source. Write down each place it fails.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Test on your Friday update draft. Case 1: put in last month's date and see if the draft catches it. Case 2: change one number and check the summary line. Case 3: delete the owner's name and see what the draft puts in its place.

Keep the failure list with the draft. Run the same 5 cases again after the tool updates.

2 Prompt Engineering at Scale

Save the prompt you reuse every week in one file. Give it a name and a date. Change one line at a time, then test the new line on last week's work before you keep it.

> EXAMPLE
>
> File entry: Update prompt v4, Oct 15. Change: added, open with the number. Test: ran it on last week's notes. Result: the summary dropped from 9 lines to 4.

In about a month the file shows what you changed and what each change fixed.

3 AI Product Sense

Before you build anything with AI, fill one page. Line 1: the problem, in one sentence. Line 2: the cheaper fix that skips AI. Line 3: the number you will check in 30 days.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Problem: my Monday report takes about 2 hours. Cheaper fix: cut the 2 sections nobody reads. Number: report done in 45 minutes by Nov 15, or the build stops.

If the cheaper fix solves it, take it. Spend your AI time on a problem that still needs it.

4 Agentic Systems Design

Pick one task you repeat every week. Write its steps in order. Mark each step one of two ways: AI runs it alone, or AI drafts it and you say yes before it moves.

> **EXAMPLE**
> Meeting follow-up: transcript, AI alone. Owners list, AI alone. Follow-up email draft, your yes. Send, you. The email carries your name, so it waits for your yes.

Start with 3 or 4 steps. Add a step only after the chain runs clean twice.

5 Responsible AI Implementation

For one AI task, write down who gets hurt if the output is wrong. Then write what you check before it ships, and keep that note with the work.

> **EXAMPLE**
> Task: an AI draft of a customer email. Hurt if wrong: the customer acts on a wrong date. Check before it ships: read the date and the price against the source doc, every time.

Keep the note. If an output goes wrong later, the note shows what you checked and when.

Practice on this one

Build your evaluation test this week. Take one AI draft, run the 5 hard cases from skill 1, and write the failures down before the draft goes out.

Score your setup

- ☐ Did I run 5 hard cases on one AI draft before I sent it?
- ☐ Is my weekly prompt saved in one file, with a date and the last change?
- ☐ Did I write the problem, the cheaper fix, and the number before building?
- ☐ Is one repeat task mapped, with my yes marked on the steps that carry risk?
- ☐ Did I write who a wrong output hurts, and what I check before it ships?
- ☐ Did I read the final draft once for names, dates, and numbers?

And always remember, I'm rooting for you.